most nonchalantly from school in the snow. This experience made me quite independent from an early age.

We were in France for three years, from November 1965 to November 1968. During each of the summer holidays, which were in July–August, we used to go on a trip somewhere or the other. One of the earliest trips was to London, where my father's batchmate, Squadron Leader Aggarwal, was the assistant air attaché, his counterpart so to speak. Crossing the English Channel by ferry, which was a roll-on roll-off type, was an exciting and novel experience. On the return leg, we had stopped at the Cherbourg Peninsula, the site of the Normandy landings, my father being a military history buff. In London, we stayed with the Aggarwals, who had two children, Pradeep and Kavita, who were of the same age as my brother and me, so we got along famously. So famously in fact, that when they came over on a reciprocal visit to Paris, Pradeep and Kavita did not want to go for any sightseeing but just wanted to stay at home and play. Later, our fathers were posted in Delhi at about the same time and we used to stay in Dhaula Kuan. So we remained in touch then and off and on over the years, till even now. Some might even remember Kavita; she was the scorer-cum-time-keeper on the first-ever TV quiz show on Doordarshan, hosted by Siddhartha Basu, called 'Quiz Time'.

Another year we went Northwards through Europe and the 'Low Countries' all the way to Boliden, Sweden, where my uncle, Papi Mama resided. Papi Mama had studied in the UK, married a Finnish lady, Helena, and he had permanently settled in Sweden, although he retained his Indian citizenship. We had great fun there, playing with our cousins Iravati, Ravindra and Amalendu. They could not speak any French nor could we speak Swedish, but somehow, we still managed to get along. I remember that once during that stay, I woke up with the sun

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